

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN PAINTINGS

MODULE - 2

**MURAL PAINTINGS
OF INDIA**

CLASSIFICATION OF INDIAN PAINTINGS

MURAL PAINTINGS



- 1 The works on the walls of a solid structure are referred to as Murals.
- 2 These have existed in India since ancient times and can be dated between 2nd century BC and 10th century AD.
- 3 The evidence of such paintings can be found in at several locations in India.
- 4 The beauty and the exquisiteness of mural paintings can be seen in places like Ajanta, Armamalai Cave, Ravan Chhaya Cave shelters, Bagh, Sittanavasal and Kailasanatha temple in Ellora.

CLASSIFICATION OF INDIAN PAINTINGS

MURAL PAINTINGS

- 5 Most of the mural paintings are in either natural caves or rock-cut chambers.
- 6 The paintings follow a theme, the most common being Hindu, Buddhist and Jain.
- 7 Apart from this, such paintings were also made to adorn any mundane premise.
- 8 An example of such a work can be seen in the ancient theatre room in Jogimara Cave.
- 9 The Mural paintings are unique because of their sheer size.
- 10 They cannot be contained on paper and need to be executed on the walls of large structures, usually caves and temple walls.
- 11 In ancient period, these were utilised by three major religions: Buddhism, Jainism and Hinduism.
- 12 Some of the best examples are: murals in the Ajanta- Ellora Caves.

INDIAN PAINTINGS AND THEIR ANTIQUITY



Bhimbetka cave paintings

- 1** The Bhimbetka Cave Paintings are an example of prehistoric cave paintings.
- 2** Reference to painted palaces are also found in the Ramayana and the Mahabharata.
- 3** Further, the Buddhist text Vinay Pitaka, gives reference to pleasure halls with walls adorned with pictures and halls painted with designs and figures.

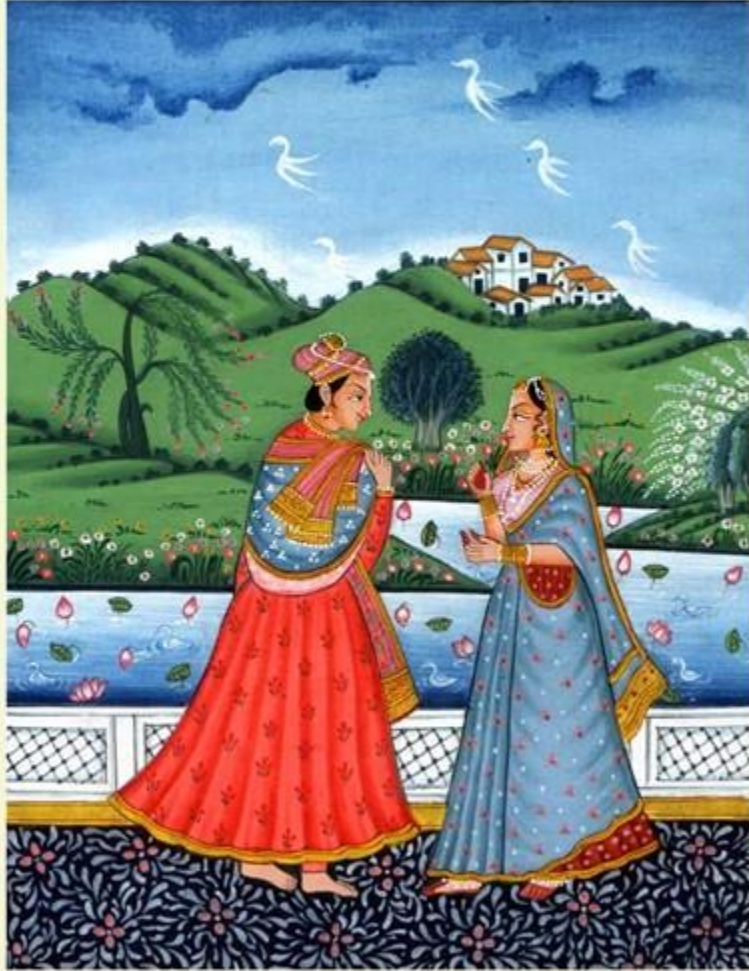
INDIAN PAINTINGS AND THEIR ANTIQUITY



Ajanta caves

- 4** One of the most important centres and a veritable treasure trove of paintings is the Ajanta caves, which contains paintings on its walls dating from the 2nd Century BCE to 7th Century CE.
- 5** This was followed by the cave paintings in Ellora (at the end of the first millennia and beginning of the second).
- 6** While earlier, the location of paintings was restricted to the walls of caves, the medieval period saw adornment of the walls and ceilings of a number of temples in South India with paintings.

INDIAN PAINTINGS AND THEIR ANTIQUITY



Pahari school of art

- 7 Such murals are found in the Pallava, Pandya, Chola and Nayaka periods, in the temples of Vijayanagar empire and even in the temples in Kerala (in the 16th to 18th Century).
- 8 The art of painting also saw emergence of a number of local schools such as the Pala art, the Rajasthan School, the Himachal paintings, the Mughal miniatures etc.

MURAL PAINTINGS

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AJANTA CAVE PAINTINGS

- 1 One of the oldest surviving murals of Indian subcontinent, Ajanta caves were carved in 4th century AD out of volcanic rocks.

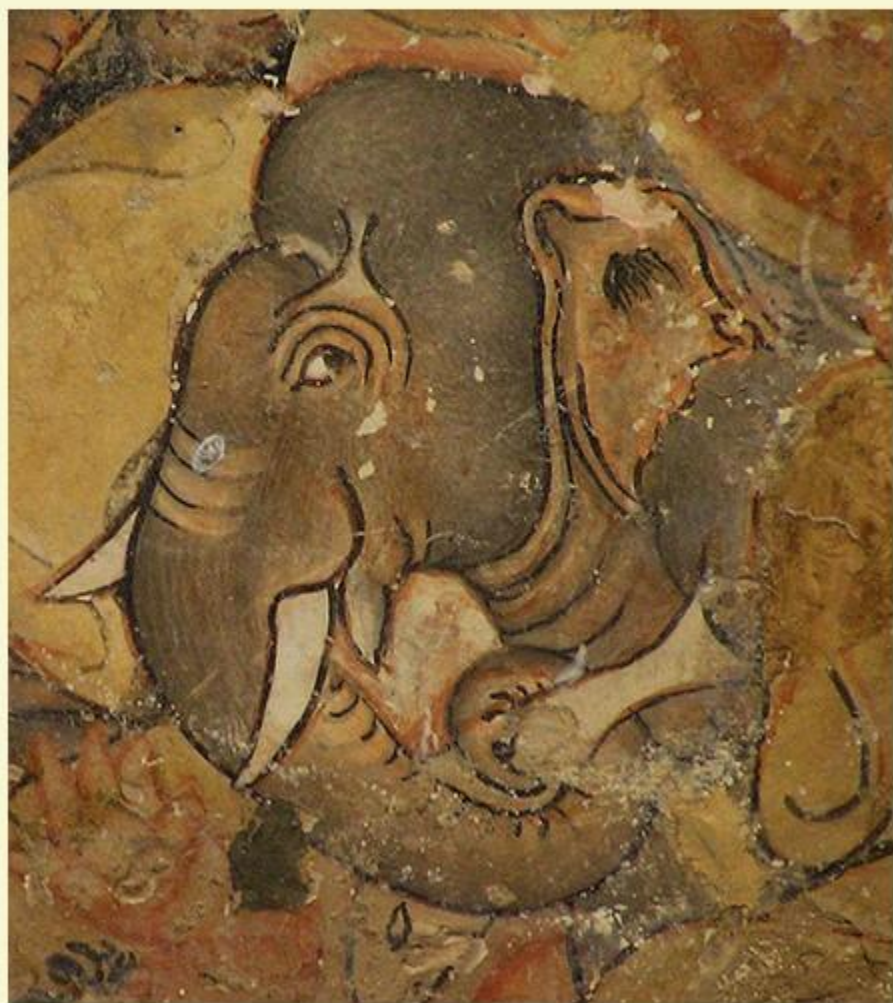


- 2 It consists of a set of 29 caves, carved in a horse-shoe shape.
- 3 These caves are quite popular for their exquisite mural paintings that took around four to five centuries to complete under the reign of various dynasties.
- 4 Murals in cave no.9 and 10 belong to the Sunga period, while the rest belong to the Gupta period.
- 5 The paintings in cave no.1 and 2 are the most recent of the caves in Ajanta.

MURAL PAINTINGS

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AJANTA CAVE PAINTINGS



- 6 The walls of the caves have both murals and fresco paintings (painted on wet plaster).
- 7 They use tempera style, i.e. use of pigments.
- 8 The paintings portray human values and social fabric along with styles, costumes and ornaments of that period.
- 9 The emotions are expressed through hand gestures.
- 10 The unique feature of the paintings is that each female figure has a unique hairstyle.
- 11 Even animals and birds are shown with emotions.

MURAL PAINTINGS

1

AJANTA CAVE PAINTINGS



Jataka tales

12 The common themes of these paintings range from **Jataka stories** to life of Buddha to elaborate decorative patterns of flora and fauna.

13 Graceful poses of humans and animals adorn the walls of the caves.

14 The medium of painting was **vegetable and mineral dyes**.

15 The outline of the figure is red ochre, with contours of brown, black or deep red.

MURAL PAINTINGS

2

ELLORA CAVE PAINTINGS

- 1 The Ellora caves are known not only for the rock-cut caves and great sculptures, but also for mural paintings found in the Hindu and Jain Caves.
- 2 These paintings date to 8th to 10th Century and are found on the ceilings and in some cases on the walls of the Jain Temples.
- 3 They are somewhat preserved in the Kailasa temple.
- 4 The features of the subjects are distinct from that of the earlier Ajanta paintings and is notable for sharp twists of head, sharp nose, elongated, open and protruding eyes, angular bent of arms, etc.
- 5 The paintings are contained in rectangular panels with wide borders. Thus, they do not have the large spread like the Ajanta paintings.

MURAL PAINTINGS

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ELLORA CAVE PAINTINGS

6 The mural paintings in the Ellora caves are found in five caves, mostly limited to Kailasha temple.

7 These murals were done in two phases.

8 The first phase paintings were done during the carving of the caves, while the second phase ones were done several centuries later.

9 The earlier paintings show Vishnu with his consort Lakshmi borne through the clouds by Garuda, the celestial bird.

10 The later paintings, made in Gujarat style, depict procession of Shaiva holy men. The paintings are related to all three religions.

MURAL PAINTINGS

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BAGH CAVE PAINTINGS

- 1 Representing an extension to the Ajanta school, **Bagh caves in Madhya Pradesh** with their exquisite work rank quite close to the actual Ajanta caves in terms of their design, execution and decoration.



- 2 The main difference is that the figure are more tightly modelled, have stronger outline, and more earthly and human.
- 3 Cave no.4, known as **Rang Mahal**, has beautiful murals on the walls depicting Buddhist and Jataka tales, just like those in Ajanta.
- 4 Although **scanty and decayed now**, these paintings depict religious themes in the light of contemporary lifestyle of people, thus are **more secular** in nature.

MURAL PAINTINGS

4 ARMAMALAI CAVE PAINTINGS



- 1 Situated in **Vellore district of Tamil Nadu**, these natural caves were made into **Jain temples** in 8th century.
- 2 Unbaked mud structures are located within the cave, which acted like the place of rest for Jain saints.
- 3 The beautiful colourful paintings on the walls and roof depict the tales **Astathik Palakas** (deities of eight corners) and Jainism.

MURAL PAINTINGS

5 RAVAN CHHAYA ROCK SHELTER



Murals in Ravan Chhaya caves

- 1 Located in the **Keonjhar district of Odisha**, these ancient fresco paintings on a rock shelter are in a shape of half-opened umbrella.
- 2 It is believed that this shelter acted like the royal hunting lodge.
- 3 The most noticeable painting is that of a royal procession that dates back to 7th century.

MURAL PAINTINGS

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BADAMI



Badami Caves part of a UNESCO-designated World Heritage Site– Aihole-Badami-Pattadakal in the Malaprabha river valley

- 1 Badami was the capital of the western Chalukyan dynasty which ruled the region from 543 to 598 CE.
- 2 With the decline of the Vakataka rule, the Chalukyas established their power in the Deccan.
- 3 The Chalukya king, Mangalesha, patronised the excavation of the Badami caves. He was the younger son of the Chalukya king, Pulakesi I, and the brother of Kirtivarman I.

MURAL PAINTINGS

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BADAMI



Images of Buddha in Badami caves

- 4 The inscription in the caves mention the date 578-579 CE, describes the beauty of the cave and includes the dedication of the image of Vishnu.
- 5 Thus it may be presumed that the cave was excavated in the same era and the patron records his Vaishnava affiliation. Therefore, the cave is popularly known as the Vishnu Cave.

MURAL PAINTINGS

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BADAMI



Mural works in Badami caves

6 Only a fragment of the painting has survived on the vaulted roof of the front mandapa. Paintings in this cave depict palace scenes.

7 One shows Kirtivarman, the son of Pulakesi I and the elder brother of Mangalesha, seated inside the palace with his wife and feudatories watching a dance scene.

8 Towards the corner of the panel are figures of Indra and his retinue.

MURAL PAINTINGS

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BADAMI

9 Stylistically speaking, the painting represents an extension of the tradition of mural painting from Ajanta to Badami in South India.

10 The sinuously drawn lines, fluid forms and compact composition exemplify the proficiency and maturity the artists had achieved in the sixth century CE.

11 The gracefully drawn faces of the king and the queen remind us of the style of modelling in Ajanta.

12 Their eye sockets are large, eyes are half-closed, and lips are protruding.

13 It is noteworthy to observe that the contours of different parts of the face create protruding structures of the face itself. Thus, with simple line treatment artists could create volume.

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